TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

A data-forward analysis of programming language popularity trends for software engineering leads and technology strategists

Methodology: Ratings are calculated from search-engine hit counts across Google, Amazon, Wikipedia, Bing, and more than 20 other sites.
The index reflects how much a language is discussed and sought after on the public internet — not lines of code written.

Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index | Captured: April 10, 2026 | Author: Paul Jansen, CEO, TIOBE Software

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Top 20 Programming Languages — March 2026 vs. March 2025

Rank 2026	Rank 2025	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

The top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, Java) collectively account for 48.97% of the total index.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ BIGGEST GAINERS

Perl — +1.05%
24th → 11th — +13 spots ▲

R — +0.94%
16th → 9th — +7 spots ▲

Swift — +0.44%
26th → 20th — +6 spots ▲

C — +2.02%
4th → 2nd — +2 spots ▲

▼ BIGGEST LOSERS

Go — -1.49%
7th → 16th — -9 spots ▼

C++ — -2.90%
2nd → 3rd — -1 spot ▼

Java — -2.37%
3rd → 4th — -1 spot ▼

Python — -2.59%
1st → 1st — 0 spots ▼

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Key Historical Patterns (2002–2026)

- Python's meteoric rise: From ~8th in 2006 to #1 after 2018, peaking above 25% before settling at 21.25%
- C's resilience: Held a top-2 position for most of the 24-year span, with surges around 2015 and 2025–2026
- Java's long decline: Dominated from 2005–2018 at 25%+, now fallen under 8%
- JavaScript's plateau: Despite web dominance, never exceeded ~5% on TIOBE; currently 3.45%
- C is the only language to remain in the top 2 across all nine measurement points from 1986 to 2026

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Awarded to the language with the largest gain in ratings during a calendar year

Python: 6 wins total

2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024 — more than any other language in TIOBE history

C#: Recent momentum

Won in both 2023 and 2025, reflecting continued growth driven by the .NET ecosystem

Go: From winner to decline

2016 Language of the Year winner, now fell from 7th to 16th — the sharpest drop in the top 20

Note on 2017

The 2017 winner is not available in the source data

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

1. Python: Dominant but declining

At 21.25%, Python leads by 2× over C, but its -2.59% YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Plan for talent retention and watch for ecosystem fragmentation.

2. C's resurgence signals systems investment

C gained +2.02% and climbed from 4th to 2nd. For low-level and embedded projects, C expertise is becoming more valuable.

3. Legacy languages are reviving

Perl (+13 spots), R (+7 spots), and Fortran (top 15) show entrenched communities in data science and infrastructure.

4. Go's sharp fall demands caution

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49%) — the largest absolute drop. Rust (+0.09%) may be displacing it in systems programming.

5. Concentration risk in the top 4

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of the index. Diversifying language investments reduces dependency on a handful of ecosystems.

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